

Consonant sounds

THERE ARE 21 CONSONANTS IN THE ENGLISH LANGUAGE:
THE WHOLE ALPHABET MINUS THE FIVE VOWELS.

Most consonants have one phoneme, or sound, but some have multiple sounds. Like vowels, consonants are written down as graphemes—letters that represent sounds.

Single consonant sounds

Single consonant sounds are sounds that are represented by consonants. For example, the single consonant sound “f” is heard in the word *fan*, and this is represented by the grapheme *f*. However, the single consonant sound “f” can also be

heard in the word *phase*; here, it is represented by the grapheme *ph*. The letters *c*, *q*, and *x* do not have single consonant sounds, but are often paired with other letters to form digraphs or blends.

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b

▽ The “b” sound

This consonant is represented by the graphemes *b* and *bb*.

bat

rabbit

d

▽ The “d” sound

This consonant is represented by the graphemes *d*, *dd*, and *ed*.

dog

puddle

rained

f

▽ The “f” sound

This consonant is represented by the graphemes *f*, *ff*, *gh*, and *ph*.

flamingo

puff

laugh

dolphin

g

▽ The “g” sound

This consonant is represented by the graphemes *g*, *gh*, *gg*, and *gu*.

girl

ghost

haggle

guinea

h

▽ The “h” sound

This consonant is represented by the graphemes *h* and *wh*.

hen

who

j

▽ The “j” sound

This consonant is represented by the graphemes *ge*, *gg*, *gi*, *gy*, *j*, and *dge*.

gerbil

suggest

giraffe

gymnast

jaguar

badger

k

▽ The “k” sound

This consonant is represented by the graphemes *c*, *cc*, *ch*, *ck*, *k*, and *que*.

cat

raccoon

chameleon

duck

kitten

mosque

l

▽ The “l” sound

This consonant is represented by the graphemes *l* and *ll*.

lion

bull

m

▽ The “m” sound

This consonant is represented by the graphemes *m*, *mb*, *mm*, and *mn*.

mouse

hummingbird

lamb

column

n

▽ The “n” sound

This consonant is represented by the graphemes *gn*, *kn*, *n*, and *nn*.

gnome knot newt sunny

p

▽ The “p” sound

This consonant is represented by the graphemes *p* and *pp*.

pig

puppy

r

▽ The “r” sound

This consonant is represented by the graphemes *r*, *rh*, *rr*, and *wr*.

rat

rhinoceros

parrot

wren

s

▽ The “s” sound

This consonant is represented by the graphemes *c*, *s*, *sc*, *ss*, and *st*.

cell

salamander

science

hiss

whistle